Revolutionary Theatre in the Digital Age: Building a Multimodal Archive for Portugal's Ongoing Revolutionary Process

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Since the mid-1990s, the Centre for Theatre Studies (University of Lisbon) has produced and maintained a variety of digital resources, enabling open access to over five centuries of Portuguese theatre history through digital libraries, databases, virtual reconstructions, and other platforms. With a well-established tradition in archival research, these resources encompass a diverse range of records, including an iconographic database (OPSIS) and a podcast (Tu cá tu lá), thereby contributing to the Digital Humanities' audio-visual turn, as discussed by Arnold and Tilton (2022).

In September 2024, the FCT-funded project PREC.PT: Theatre and Performance during the Ongoing Revolutionary Process (FCT 2023.10644.25ABR) officially started. Its objective is to understand the role of theatre and performance in the construction of democracy in Portugal during the Ongoing Revolutionary Process (April 1974–November 1975). Fifty years after the Carnation Revolution of April 25, 1974, there is an urgent need for a comprehensive study of this period, utilizing both contemporary documents and the memories of those involved in the theatrical system during the revolutionary process.

Drawing on Miguel Escobar Varela (2021) understanding of theatre as data, the main data sources of the PREC.PT project are archival documents and interviews, placing the project at the intersection of theatre studies, digital humanities, and oral history. The latter plays a central role, aligning the investigation with recent developments in theatre historiography (Ableiovich 2023; Demetriou 2017). During Phase 1 of the project, archival information has been collected, systematised, and modelled into a dataset detailing a timeline of performances and theatre-related events during the 18-month period of the Ongoing Revolutionary Process. Simultaneously, a set of audio recordings from interviews has been deposited in a cloud repository and they are being edited for online publication following final validation by the narrators. The processing of documents and interviews remains underway, reflecting the ongoing effort to transform traces into data – the *datatrace*, as proposed by Clarisse Bardiot (2021).

An initial analysis of the audio data not only supports the notion that "incomplete or sometimes lost records from the near past can to some extent be complemented with memories and materials from personal collections" (Dobreva / Jennings 2018: 174) but also highlights the dynamic nature of embodied experiences and the strongly affective quality of personal memories associated with this period. More significantly, they have contributed to shape the project's design, moving beyond a collaborative approach to adopt participatory practices within a citizen science framework. For instance, many narrators highlighted how the revolutionary process extended beyond the strict 18-month timeframe, with its origins in the independent theatre movements and aesthetic innovations of the long 70s. Similarly, the social transformations initiated during this period, such as theatre decentralization, continued to influence Portuguese theatre well into the following decade. Pragmatically, this realisation, along with ethical considerations, led to the decision of enlarging the timeframe of the interviews to accommodate and contextualise the perceptions of the narrators. This was not the case regarding the timeline, for the expansion of the chronological boundaries would compromise its viability.

On a technological level, challenges ranging from linguistic obstacles – the interviews are in Portuguese, which makes more difficult the use of Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR) – to issues related with data format discrepancies are now being addressed. The framework of Multimodal Digital Oral History (MDOH), as proposed by Smyth, Nyhan, and Flinn (2023), seems to encapsulate possible solutions. The call for moving beyond the segmentation of interviews and harness the potential of digital methods and resources to "reposition and interweave the transcript as one layer among many" (Smyth, Nyhan, and Flinn 2023: 725) aligns with the goals laid down for PREC.PT online archive. This approach would circumvent the static interrelation between audio-visual record and the transcript that characterises many web interfaces of Oral History collections, promoting more interactive aways to explore the project collection. Advances in tagging, indexing, and analysing audio records—including paralinguistic features such as sound and emotions— have the potential to offer new possibilities for processing and naviga-

ting archives. Would it be possible, then, to integrate paralinguistic and text-based annotations effectively not only for data analysis but also to improve discoverability? More broadly, how can the digital environment enable the seamless integration of sources in various formats to generate a more holistic understanding of the subject matter?

This presentation will reflect on the lessons learned during the collection and documentation of the PREC.PT project's sources. It will interrogate the potential of digital resources for annotation, access, and discovery, with the ultimate aim of developing a robust, FAIR digital archive of Theatre and Performance During the Ongoing Revolutionary Process.

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